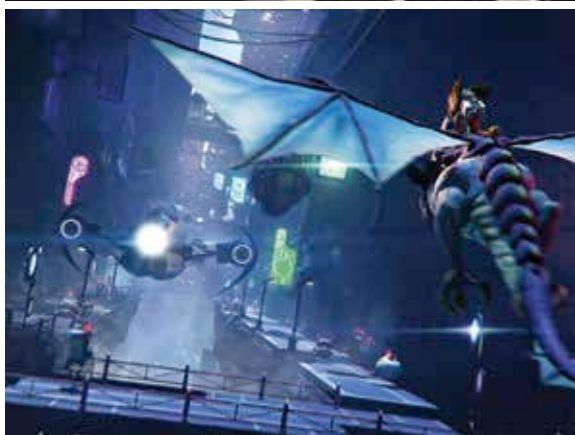


there are some new elements here as well. A dash that makes you temporarily invulnerable, new weapons in your arsenal, and some new traversal tricks, help make the gameplay feel fresh. Let's break it down.

At its heart, the gameplay is the same we have come to love from previous entries in the franchise. It is a third person action-adventure game. You play the game as both Ratchet and Rivet and their gameplay mechanics, abilities and weapons are identical. So, when one character gets a new ability, weapon or upgrade, the same is reflected with the other character. Whether this is a good or a bad thing is entirely up to you. Considering the variety in weapons on offer, the gameplay is pretty diverse.

Speaking of weapons, in true Ratchet and Clank fashion we have an interesting mix of some old and new weapons on offer and the weapons make use of the Adaptive Triggers on the DualSense controller. The Burst Pistol, for example, will fire slow, but accurate, rounds when the trigger is half pulled. When pulled completely, the gun will fire rapid but less accurate rounds. The same for the Enforcer (the game's version of a shotgun). Pull the trigger halfway for a single barrel shot or pull it completely for a double barrel shot. The NegaTron Collider charges up as you half pull the trigger and fully pulling it lets out a charge. This makes the adaptive triggers quite useful for these weapons. In some weapons, like the grenade launcher, half pulling the trigger brings up the aiming reticle, which can also be achieved by holding down the left trigger. Some weapons are traditional in their firing mechanism (like the sniper rifle) and only use the added tension in the trigger for an immersive experience.

There are a bunch of new weapons at your disposal this time around.



There is the Ricochet, which as the name suggests, ricochets on enemies a few times. There is also the Topiary Sprinkler that freezes enemies in place by converting them into plants. And then you have Mr Fungi who hovers around you and fires a swarm of fungus spores. In the heat of battle, Mr Fungi can also distract enemies and draw fire away from you.

There are more than 20 weapons that are in your arsenal for you to mix up the gameplay. Like traditional Ratchet and Clank games, the more you use your weapons, the more powerful they get. You can also visit Mrs. Zircon who is the weapons vendor and not only can you buy weapons from her, but also upgrade them.

The level design in Ratchet and Clank: Rift Apart has seen some

changes. To begin with, there are vast open areas you will explore with multiple quest objectives along with some side objectives and collectables. There are also the standard cinematic set pieces that will keep you at the edge of your seat. The new highlight here is the ability to jump from one level to the next by using a rift and the SSD loads a new level in a matter of seconds making the game feel truly next-gen. While these rift jumps are scripted, their implementation is very impressive. Once you boot up the game, it doesn't take more than a second or 2 to load it from the save menu or even when you die. It's truly amazing.

The game is filled with some truly frantic battles and while you can choose a set of favourite guns and stick to them for the duration of the game, I highly recommend giving each weapon a chance as they truly diversify the experience.

The only downside to the gameplay is the boss battles. While there are diverse planets to explore and some truly epic

battles, most of them culminate with the same four large enemies making the boss battles quite repetitive. Think of these as the same Trolls recycled as mini boss fights throughout 2018's God of War. Sure, the Dr Nefarious battles are a standout highlight, but the game could do with some more varying boss battles.

You also have pocket dimensions you can visit which are platforming challenges and usually end with some reward. You also take control of Clank for some puzzle sequences and a small hacking robot for some action-packed hacking sequences and all these are a fun distraction from the main game. Overall, the gameplay of Ratchet and Clank: Rift Apart is frantic and fun with the only downside